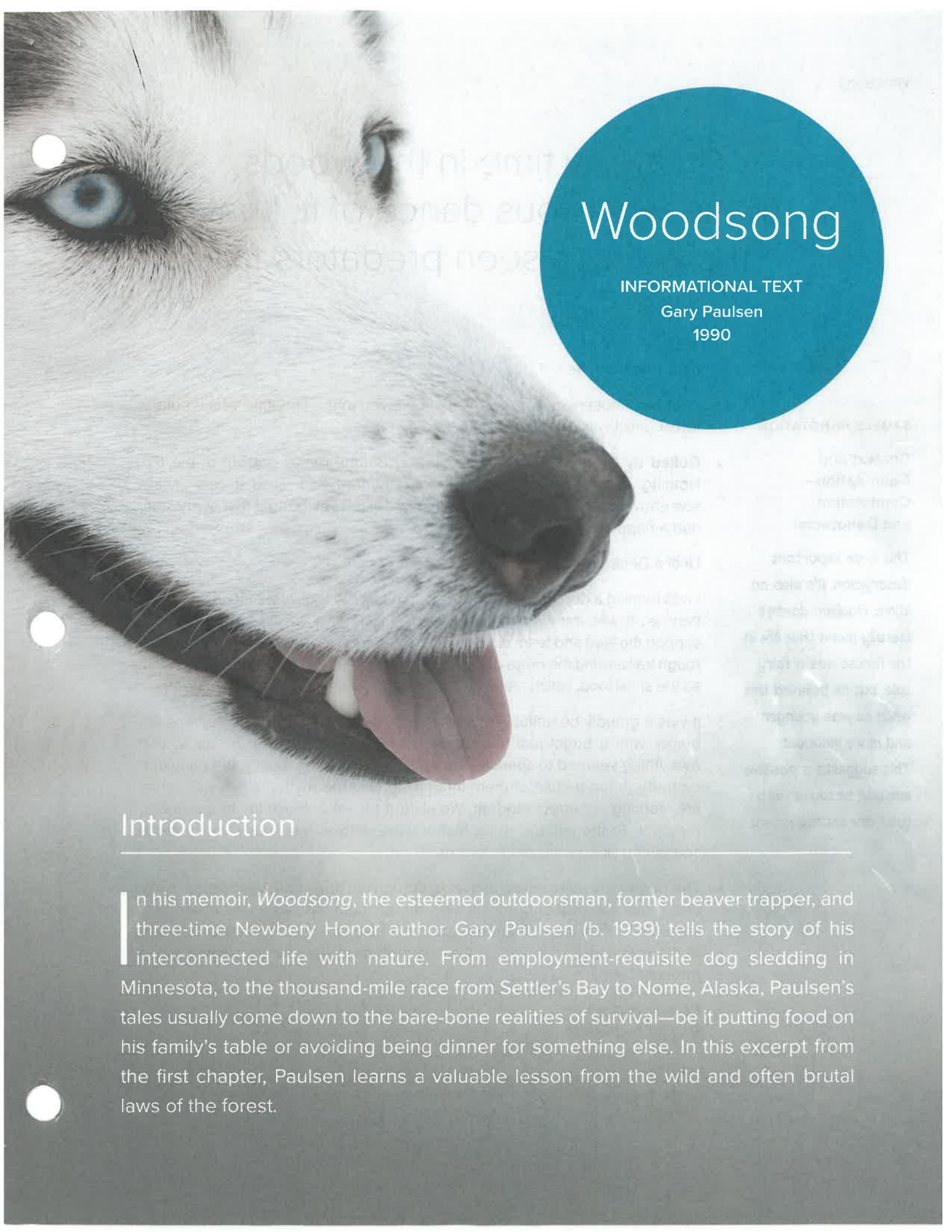




Woodsong

INFORMATIONAL TEXT

Gary Paulsen
1990

Introduction

In his memoir, *Woodsong*, the esteemed outdoorsman, former beaver trapper, and three-time Newbery Honor author Gary Paulsen (b. 1939) tells the story of his interconnected life with nature. From employment-requisite dog sledding in Minnesota, to the thousand-mile race from Settler's Bay to Nome, Alaska, Paulsen's tales usually come down to the bare-bone realities of survival—be it putting food on his family's table or avoiding being dinner for something else. In this excerpt from the first chapter, Paulsen learns a valuable lesson from the wild and often brutal laws of the forest.

“In all my time in the woods,
in the wondrous dance of it, I have
many times seen predators fail.”

NOTES

SAMPLE ANNOTATION

Context and
Connotation –
Connotation
and Denotation

This is an important description. It's also an idiom. Paulsen doesn't literally mean that life in the forest was a fairy tale, but he believed this when he was younger and more innocent. This suggests a positive emotion because fairy tales are usually happy.

from Chapter One

- 1 I lived in innocence for a long time. I believed in the fairy-tale version of the forest until I was close to forty years old.
- 2 **Gulled** by Disney and others, I believed Bambi always got out of the fire. Nothing ever really got hurt. Though I hunted and killed it was always somehow clean and removed from reality. I killed yet thought that every story had a happy ending.
- 3 Until a December morning . . .
- 4 I was running a dog team around the side of a large lake, just starting out on my trapline¹. It was early winter and the ice on the lake wasn't thick enough to support the sled and team or I would have gone across the middle. There was a rough trail around the edge of the lake and I was running a fresh eight-dog team so the small loop, which added five or so miles, presented no great difficulty.
- 5 It was a grandly beautiful winter morning. The temperature was perhaps ten below, with a bright sun that shone through ice crystals in the air so that everything seemed to sparkle. The dogs were working evenly, the gangline² up through the middle of them thrumming with the rhythm it has when they are working in perfect **tandem**. We skirted the lake, which lay below and to the right. To the left and rising higher were willows and brush, which made something like a wall next to the trail.
- 6 The dogs were still running at a lope, though we had come over seven miles, and I was full of them; my life was full of them. We were, as it happens sometimes, dancing with winter. I could not help smiling, just smiling idiotically at the grandness of it. Part of the chant of an ancient Navajo prayer rolled through my mind:
- 7 *Beauty above me
Beauty below me*

1. **trapline** a route along which traps are set for wild animals or other game
2. **gangline** the central line in front of a sled to which each individual animal is attached

Beauty before me . . .

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- 8 That is how I felt then and frequently still feel when I am running dogs. I was in and of beauty and at that **precise** moment a doe, a white-tailed deer, exploded out of some willows on the left side of the team, heading down the bank toward the lake.
- 9 The snow alongside the trail was about two feet deep and powdery and it followed her in a white shower that covered everything. She literally flew over the lead dog who was a big, white, wolfy-looking male named Dollar. He was so surprised that he dropped, ducked, for part of an instant, then rose—almost like a rock skipping on the trail—and continued running. We were moving so fast and the deer was moving so fast that within a second or two we were several yards past where it happened and yet everything seemed suspended in slow motion.
- 10 Above all, in the deer, was the stink of fear. Even in that split part of a second, it could be smelled. It could be seen. The doe's eyes were so wide they seemed to come out of her head. Her mouth was jacked open and her tongue hung out to the side. Her jaw and neck were covered with spit, and she stunk of fear.
- 11 Dogs smell fear at once but I have not always been able to, even when I was afraid. There is something coppery about it, a metallic smell mixed with the smell of urine and feces, when something, when somebody, is afraid. No, not just afraid but ripped with fear, and it was on the doe.
- 12 The smell excited the dogs and they began to run faster, although continuing down the trail; I turned to look back from the sled and saw why the doe was frightened.
- 13 Wolves.
- 14 They bounded over the trail after the doe even as I watched. These were not the large timber wolves but the smaller northern brush wolves, perhaps weighing forty or fifty pounds each, about as large as most of my team. I think they are called northern coyotes.
- 15 Except that they act as wolves. They pack and have pack social structures like timber wolves, and hunt in packs like timber wolves.
- 16 And they were hunting the doe.
- 17 There were seven of them and not one looked down the trail to see me as they jumped across the sled tracks after the deer. They were so **intent** on her, and the smell of her, that I might as well not have existed.
- 18 And they were gaining on her.

SAMPLE ANNOTATION

**Context and
Connotation –
Connotation
and Denotation**

The dictionary definition of stink is “give off an unpleasant smell,” which has negative connotations. Using the phrase stunk of fear rather than smelled of fear emphasizes just how terrified the deer is as she runs from the wolves.



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- 19 I stood on the brakes to stop the sled and set the snow-hook to hold the dogs and turned. The dogs immediately swung down off the trail toward the lake, trying to get at the wolves and deer. The snowhook came loose and we began to slide down the lake bank. I jerked the hook from the snow and hooked it on a small poplar that held us.
- 20 The doe, in horror now, and knowing what was coming, left the bank of the lake and bounded out onto the bad ice. Her tail was fully erect, a white flash as she tried to reach out and get speed, but the ice was too thin.
- 21 Too thin for all the weight of her on the small, pointed hooves and she went through and down in a huge spray of shattered ice and water.
- 22 She was up instantly, clambering and working to get back up on top of the ice next to the hole. Through sheer effort in her panic she made it.
- 23 But it slowed her too much.
- 24 In those few moments of going through the ice and getting out she lost her lead on the wolves and they were on her.

SAMPLE ANNOTATION

Purpose and Perspective

The repetition of the phrase *on her* emphasizes the lasting impression this event left on the author. Finishing with “but this time it was not to be” highlights how the death of the doe changes the author’s perspective of nature.

- 25 On her.
- 26 In all my time in the woods, in the wondrous dance of it, I have many times seen predators fail. As a matter of fact, they usually fail. I once saw a beaver come out of a hole on the ice near his lodge in the middle of winter and stand off four wolves. He **sustained** one small bite on his tail and **inflicted** terrible damage with his teeth on the wolves, killing one and wounding the other three. I have seen rabbits outwit foxes and watched red squirrels tease martens and get away with it, but this time it was not to be.

Excerpted from *Woodsong* by Gary Paulsen, published by Simon & Schuster.

